Governor time to garrison and refortify all Shuja's likely invasion routes. By the time the Shah had succeeding in raising sufficient money to finance an army against the jewels Wa'fa Begum had smuggled out to Ludhiana, then to recruit and train the mercenary force, the secret was out and the campaigning season was over.

But Shuja disdained advice to wait until the arrival of spring. He set off with his new troops over the Jot Pass, up the Chamba Valley, just as the first of the winter snow was beginning to dust the peaks of the Himalayas. In an attempt to reach the Kashmir Valley by an unexpected and unfortified route, he decided to take his troops across the heights of the Pir Panjal. Here, on a bleak ridge high above the dark spires of the deodar forests, only a few days' march from Srinagar, the force was caught in a blizzard. Shuja's men found themselves trapped just below the top of the pass, blocked in by snow and exposed to the elements. 'There was no way to advance or retreat,' Shuja wrote later, 'and soon no food and no water. Not knowing how to survive in the snow, the Hindustani troops began to die of the cold.' Before long the small army was almost wiped out. Only Shah Shuja and a small group of survivors made it over the top of the pass, and hence back to the plains.[13] As one British writer put it when he heard the news, 'Misfortune seemed to follow in the footsteps of this Prince . . . It seemed as if he was but warring against his Fate, which was, over and again, to experience hardships such as fall to the lot of few men.'[14]

Shuja's condition was now desperate. In disguise once again, he took an arduous and circuitous route over the mountains with his last few attendants and finally reached the British frontier post of Subbathu in the monsoon of 1816. Met at the border by a small escort, he was taken to Ludhiana. Here his harem had found shelter in a modest haveli near the principal bazaar. 'Our cares were now forgotten,' he wrote. 'Giving thanks to Almighty God who, having freed us from our enemies and led us through the trackless snows, now conducted us to our friends, we passed a night for the first time with comfort, and without dread.'[15]

In 1816, Ludhiana was the British garrison town on the Company's North West Frontier. From the flagpole of its Residency flew the last Union Jack between the Company's Indian possessions and the British Embassy in St Petersburg.